

Word family: **firm / firmer / firmest / firmly / firmness**

Base word: firm

Comparative: firmer

Superlative: firmest

Part of speech: mainly **adjective** and **noun**, also **verb**

Related forms:

* **firm** (adj.) — 堅定的；牢固的；結實的；明確的

* **firmly** (adv.) — 堅定地；牢牢地

* **firmness** (n.) — 堅定；堅實；硬度

* **firm** (n.) — 公司；商號

* **firm** (v.) — 使變堅實；使穩固；變硬

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **firm teacher**

* **firm but fair**

* **firm decision**

* **firm belief**

* **firm grip**

* **firm ground**

* **firm mattress**

* **firm flesh**

* **firm answer**

* **firm commitment**

* **stand firm**

* **hold firm**

* **firm up**

* **law firm**

* **accounting firm**

* **consulting firm**

Meaning in this passage

> He was **firm**, but fair, and that balance is not easy to find.

Here, **firm** means:

strong and clear in enforcing rules or decisions, without being easily persuaded to change — 堅定的；有原則的；不輕易讓步的

The speaker means Mr Chan was not soft or permissive, but he was also not unfair.

****中文翻譯：****

他很****有原則 / 堅定****，但同時也很公道。

So here:

****firm but fair = 有原則但公平；要求嚴謹但不苛刻****

1. ****firm (人 / 態度：堅定的) — 堅定的；有原則的****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He was ****firm****, but fair.

他很****有原則 / 堅定****，但同時也很公平。

Practice 2

> She is a ****firm**** teacher who expects students to follow the rules.

她是一位很****有原則的老師****，要求學生遵守規則。

Practice 3

> You need to be ****firm**** without being rude.

你需要****堅定****，但不要無禮。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm = 對規則、決定或立場保持明確，不輕易被說服改變****

2. ****firm but fair — 嚴而有理；堅定但公平****

A very common and useful expression.

Practice 1

> A good teacher can be ****firm but fair****.

好老師可以做到**有原則但公平**。

Practice 2

> Her management style is **firm but fair**.

她的管理方式**嚴謹但公道**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm but fair = 對標準和規則要求明確，但處理事情仍然公平合理****

3. ****firm decision — 堅定的決定；已確定的決定****

Practice 1

> She made a ****firm decision**** to leave.

她作出了一個****堅定的決定****要離開。

Practice 2

> We need a ****firm decision**** by Friday.

我們需要在星期五前作出一個****明確決定****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm decision = 已清楚決定、不容易改變的決定****

4. ****firm belief / conviction — 堅定的信念****

Practice 1

> He has a ****firm belief**** in education.

他對教育有****堅定信念****。

Practice 2

> She remained ****firm in her belief**** that the plan would work.

她仍然****堅信****這個計劃會成功。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm belief = 強烈而穩定、不容易動搖的信念****

5. ****firm opinion / position — 堅定意見 / 立場****

Practice 1

> He has a ****firm opinion**** on the issue.

他對這個議題有很****明確而堅定的看法****。

Practice 2

> The school took a ****firm position**** on bullying.

學校對欺凌採取了****堅定立場****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm opinion/position = 清楚而不易改變的看法或立場****

6. ****firm answer — 明確、堅定的回答****

Practice 1

> She gave a ****firm no****.

她****堅決地拒絕了****。

Practice 2

> I need a ****firm answer**** today.

我今天需要一個****明確答覆****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm answer = 清楚、不含糊，而且不容易改變的回答****

7. ****firm commitment — 堅定承諾****

Practice 1

> The company made a **firm commitment** to reduce waste.

公司作出**堅定承諾**要減少浪費。

Practice 2

> We need a **firm commitment** from everyone involved.

我們需要所有參與者作出**明確承諾**。

MCQ-ready definition:

firm commitment = 清楚、可靠、認真而不輕易撤回的承諾

8. **stand firm** — 堅持立場；不退讓

Practice 1

> She **stood firm** despite the criticism.

即使受到批評，她仍然**堅持立場**。

Practice 2

> The teacher **stood firm** on the rule.

老師在這條規則上**沒有讓步**。

MCQ-ready definition:

stand firm = 面對壓力時仍保持原來立場或決定

9. **hold firm** — 保持堅定；維持不變

Practice 1

> Prices **held firm** despite weak demand.

儘管需求疲弱，價格仍然**保持穩定**。

Practice 2

> She **held firm** to her decision.

她**堅持自己的決定**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****hold firm = 不下降、不改變，或在壓力下仍堅持立場****

10. ****firm (物理：結實的；硬實的) — 結實的；硬實的****

A major literal branch.

Practice 1

> The mattress is quite ****firm****.

這張床褥相當****硬實****。

Practice 2

> Choose tomatoes that feel ****firm****.

選那些摸起來****結實、不軟爛的番茄****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm = 有一定硬度或結實程度，不容易被壓變形****

11. ****firm mattress / cushion — 偏硬、承托力強的床褥 / 坐墊****

Practice 1

> I prefer a ****firm mattress****.

我比較喜歡****偏硬、承托力強的床褥****。

Practice 2

> The chair has a ****firm cushion****.

這張椅子的坐墊很****結實****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm mattress/cushion = 不太柔軟、能提供較強承托力的****

12. **firm fruit / flesh** — 結實的果肉；不軟爛的

Practice 1

> The apple is still **firm**.

這個蘋果仍然很**結實爽脆**。

Practice 2

> The fish has **firm flesh**.

這種魚的肉質很**結實**。

MCQ-ready definition:

firm food/flesh = 質地結實、有彈性、不鬆軟或不軟爛的

13. **firm grip** — 緊握；牢固的握法

Practice 1

> Keep a **firm grip** on the handle.

牢牢握住把手。

Practice 2

> She held his arm with a **firm grip**.

她**牢牢地握住**他的手臂。

MCQ-ready definition:

firm grip = 有力而穩固、不容易鬆開的握持

14. **firm ground / surface** — 堅實地面 / 表面

Practice 1

> Make sure the ladder is standing on **firm ground**.

確保梯子放在**堅實地面**上。

Practice 2

> The road became **firmer** as we moved uphill.

我們往山上走時，路面變得更**堅實**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm ground/surface = 穩固、結實、不容易下陷或移動的表面****

15. ****firm (穩固的；不搖動的) — 穩固的；牢靠的****

Practice 1

> The table doesn't feel **firm**.

這張桌子感覺不夠**穩固**。

Practice 2

> Make sure the shelf is **firm** before putting books on it.

放書前先確保架子夠**牢固**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm = 結構穩定，不容易移動、倒下或鬆脫****

16. ****firm (價格 / 市場：堅挺的) — 堅挺的；穩定偏強的****

A business/economic sense.

Practice 1

> Oil prices remained **firm**.

油價保持**堅挺**。

Practice 2

> Demand is strong and prices are **firm**.

需求強勁，價格也保持**堅挺**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm prices/market = 價格或市場表現保持穩定，沒有明顯下跌****

17. ****firm (noun : 公司 ; 商號) — 公司 ; 商號****

A completely different noun sense.

Practice 1

> She works for a law ****firm****.

她在一家律師****事務所****工作。

Practice 2

> The ****firm**** employs more than 200 people.

這間****公司****聘用了二百多人。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firm = 提供專業服務或從事商業活動的公司或商號****

18. ****law firm — 律師事務所****

Practice 1

> He joined a large ****law firm****.

他加入了一家大型****律師事務所****。

Practice 2

> The ****law firm**** specializes in commercial cases.

這家****律師事務所****專門處理商業案件。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****law firm = 由律師提供法律服務的專業機構****

19. **accounting / consulting firm — 會計 / 顧問公司**

Practice 1

> She works for an **accounting firm**.

她在一家**會計師事務所**工作。

Practice 2

> The company hired a **consulting firm**.

公司聘請了一家**顧問公司**。

MCQ-ready definition:

X firm = 提供某一類專業服務的公司

20. **firm up (使更確定 ; 敲定) — 確定 ; 落實**

A very useful phrasal extension.

Practice 1

> We need to **firm up the plans**.

我們需要把計劃**進一步敲定**。

Practice 2

> Let's **firm up the details** tomorrow.

我們明天把細節**確定下來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

firm up something = 令計劃、安排或細節變得更明確、更確定

21. **firm up (使變結實) — 使更結實 ; 變緊實**

Practice 1

> Exercise can help **firm up your muscles**.

運動可以幫助令肌肉**更結實**。

Practice 2

> The mixture will **firm up** as it cools.

混合物冷卻後會**變得更硬實**。

MCQ-ready definition:

firm up = 令某物變得更結實、更硬或更穩固

22. **firmly — 堅定地**

Practice 1

> She **firmly refused** the offer.

她**堅決拒絕**了提議。

Practice 2

> He **firmly believes** that education should be fair.

他**堅信**教育應該公平。

MCQ-ready definition:

firmly = 以堅定、不容易改變的方式

23. **firmly (牢牢地) — 牢固地 ; 緊緊地**

Practice 1

> Hold the rail **firmly**.

牢牢抓住扶手。

Practice 2

> Press the lid down **firmly**.

把蓋子**用力壓緊**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firmly = 以穩固、有力、不鬆動的方式****

24. ****firmness (態度：堅定) — 堅定；堅決****

Practice 1

> She handled the situation with calmness and ****firmness****.

她以冷靜和****堅定****處理這件事。

Practice 2

> Good teaching sometimes requires ****firmness****.

良好教學有時需要一定的****堅定原則****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firmness = 不輕易讓步、能夠堅持原則的特質****

25. ****firmness (物理：硬度 / 結實度) — 硬度；結實程度****

Practice 1

> Check the ****firmness**** of the fruit.

檢查水果的****結實程度****。

Practice 2

> This mattress offers adjustable ****firmness****.

這張床褥的****軟硬度****可以調節。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****firmness = 某物硬實、結實或承托力的程度****

Important distinction 1: ****firm vs strict****

This is especially important in your passage.

****firm****

= clear, consistent, not easily pushed into changing.

****strict****

= strongly enforces rules and standards.

> a firm teacher

有原則、立場堅定的老師

> a strict teacher

要求嚴格的老師

A teacher can be ****firm without being very strict****.

Important distinction 2: ****firm vs harsh****

****firm****

can be positive:

= clear and consistent.

****harsh****

negative:

= too severe, rough, or unkind.

So:

> ****firm but fair****

is positive.

> harsh but fair

sounds much less natural because ****harsh**** already suggests excessive severity.

Important distinction 3: **firm vs mean**

Very important in this teacher passage.

firm

holds rules and boundaries.

mean

deliberately unkind.

Mr Chan can be firm **without making weaker students feel small**.

So:

firm ≠ mean

Important distinction 4: **firm vs stubborn**

firm

usually positive/neutral:
holds a reasonable position.

stubborn

often negative:
refuses to change even when there may be good reasons.

> She remained firm.

她堅持立場。

> She remained stubborn.

她仍然很固執。

The evaluation differs significantly.

Important distinction 5: **firm vs determined**

firm

often concerns maintaining a decision, rule, or position.

determined

focuses on reaching a goal.

> firm on the rules

在規則上立場堅定

> determined to succeed

決心成功

Important distinction 6: **firm vs decisive**

firm

doesn't easily change after deciding.

decisive

makes decisions quickly and clearly.

A person can be decisive but later flexible; firm but slow to decide.

Important distinction 7: **firm vs solid**

For physical objects:

firm

resists pressure but may still have some give.

solid

not liquid/hollow, or very strong/stable.

> firm mattress

偏硬床褥

> solid wall

實心 / 堅固牆壁

A mattress should be firm, not necessarily “solid.”

Important distinction 8: **firm** vs **hard**

hard

often stronger: very resistant to pressure.

firm

less extreme: comfortably resistant, stable, or supportive.

> firm fruit

結實成熟的水果

> hard fruit

可能硬得不自然或未成熟

So **firm** is often the more positive texture word.

Important distinction 9: **firm** vs **tight**

firm grip

strong and secure.

tight grip

strongly compressed; may imply excessive force.

A firm handshake is positive; an overly tight one may hurt.

Important distinction 10: ****firm answer vs certain answer****

****firm answer****

clear and not likely to change.

****certain answer****

can mean definitely known/correct.

> I need a firm answer.

我要你明確表態。

does not necessarily mean:

> I need the objectively correct answer.

Important distinction 11: ****firm belief vs strong belief****

These are very close.

****strong belief****

intense belief.

****firm belief****

stable and not easily shaken.

****Firm**** emphasizes resistance to change.

Important distinction 12: ****firm prices vs high prices****

****firm prices****

prices remain stable/strong and resist falling.

****high prices****

prices are expensive in absolute terms.

Prices can be low but firm.

Important distinction 13: **firm** noun vs **company**

firm

often especially natural for professional-service businesses:

- * law firm

- * accounting firm

- * consulting firm

company

broader business term.

Not every company is normally called a **firm**, although there is overlap.

Important distinction 14: **firm** vs **corporation**

firm

general/professional business organization.

corporation

specific incorporated legal business entity, especially in AmE/legal contexts.

So **firm** says less about legal structure.

Important distinction 15: **firm up plans** vs **make plans**

make plans

create plans.

firm up plans

make existing plans more definite.

> We made plans last week.

我們上星期制定了計劃。

> We need to firm them up today.

今天要把它們敲定。

Important distinction 16: ****firmly = strongly vs firmly = securely****

Two related but distinct uses:

Abstract

> firmly believe

堅信

Physical

> hold firmly

牢牢握住

The shared core is:

****not easily moved****

physically or figuratively.

Family-extension note

****Firm**** has three major modern branches:

1. ****not easily moved in attitude****

- * firm teacher
- * firm decision
- * firm belief
- * stand firm

2. ****not easily moved physically****

- * firm mattress
- * firm fruit
- * firm grip
- * firm ground

3. **business noun**

- * a firm
- * law firm
- * consulting firm

The first two are semantically connected:

physically resistant to movement/pressure

→ **mentally resistant to pressure/change**

But **firm = company** is a distinct lexical noun branch and should be taught separately.

The passage uses the **attitude/discipline** sense.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
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firm teacher/person	有原則 / 堅定的	consistent boundaries
firm but fair	堅定但公平	disciplined + fair
firm decision	堅定 / 明確決定	not easily changed
firm belief	堅定信念	stable conviction
firm position	堅定立場	maintained stance
firm answer	明確答覆	definite response
firm commitment	堅定承諾	reliable commitment
stand firm	堅持立場	resist pressure
hold firm	保持不變 / 堅持	remain stable
firm mattress	偏硬床褥	resistant/supportive
firm fruit	結實水果	not soft
firm grip	牢固握住	secure hold
firm ground	堅實地面	stable surface
firm prices	堅挺價格	resist falling
firm (noun)	公司；商號	business organization
law firm	律師事務所	legal-services business
consulting firm	顧問公司	consultancy
firm up plans	敲定計劃	make definite

firm up physically	變結實	become more solid	
firmly	堅定地 / 牢牢地	resistant to movement	
firmness	堅定 / 硬度	quality of firmness	

For your original sentence

> He was **firm**, but fair, and that balance is not easy to find.

Here:

firm = 有原則、立場清楚，而且在合理規則上不輕易讓步

The contrast with **fair** is important.

The speaker is saying Mr Chan could enforce standards and maintain discipline **without humiliating or treating students unfairly**.

So:

> **firm but fair**

is not best translated as simply:

> 嚴格但公平

because **firm** is a little more nuanced than **strict**.

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他很**有原則、立場堅定**，但同時也很公道。

or more compactly:

> 他**嚴而有理，而且公平**。

For this passage, **「有原則」** captures the personality nuance especially well.